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Joshua Nations

Lesson 4. The 3/3rds Group Format

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Lesson 4. The 3/3rds Group Format

I. INTRODUCTION TO 3-PART GROUPS

- A. **The Promise of Jesus' Presence:** Jesus said, "Where two or three have gathered together in My name, I am there in their midst" (Matthew 18:20). This powerful promise assures us that even in small gatherings, Christ is present and working among us. The 3/3 Group Format is designed to help believers take full advantage of this promise by structuring their gatherings in a way that promotes spiritual growth, accountability, and multiplication.
- B. **Purpose of 3/3 Groups:** The 3/3 format divides the group's time into three parts—**Look Back**, **Look Up**, and **Look Forward**—ensuring that key aspects of discipleship are covered: reflection on the past week, engagement with God's Word, and setting goals for the future. This format encourages obedience, personal growth, and active disciple-making.
- C. **Simplicity for Reproducibility:** Like other simple church models, the 3/3 format is designed to be easily reproducible by any believer, whether they are new to faith or experienced leaders. This simplicity helps the model spread quickly, as it can be adapted in various contexts, from small homes to workplace gatherings or even online meetings.

II. LOOK BACK (1/3 OF YOUR TIME)

- A. **Purpose:** The "Look Back" segment focuses on building community, fostering accountability, and ensuring that spiritual growth is measured not only by what we learn but by how we obey. It's a time to care for one another, celebrate victories, and reflect on how we have been following Jesus in the past week.
- B. **Care and Prayer**
 - 1. **Starting with Gratitude:** Begin by having each person share one thing they are thankful for from the past week. This fosters a spirit of gratitude and helps participants focus on God's blessings before diving into any challenges or struggles.
 - 2. **Example Questions:**
 - 1. "What are you thankful for this week?"
 - 1. "Where have you seen God at work in your life?"

3. **Sharing Struggles:** Next, ask participants to share any challenges or struggles they faced during the week, whether personal, spiritual, or relational. This builds vulnerability and trust within the group.
4. **Caring Through Prayer:** After sharing, the person to their right prays for them based on what they shared. This encourages members to take responsibility for caring for one another and strengthens the bonds within the group.
5. **Extended Care:** If someone is facing significant struggles that need more time and attention, make sure to stay after the formal group time to care for that person. This creates a culture where deep care for each other is a priority.

C. Vision Casting

1. **Setting the Tone:** Vision casting keeps the group focused on its mission and purpose: loving God, loving others, and making disciples who make disciples. This segment reminds everyone of the bigger picture and why the group exists.
2. **Worship and Song:** One way to cast vision is through singing. Choose songs that focus on themes like God's love, the Great Commission, and the call to disciple-making.
3. **Scripture for Vision:** Alternatively, members can share Bible passages that reflect key themes—such as the Great Commandment (Matthew 22:37-40) or the Great Commission (Matthew 28:18-20)—reminding the group of their call to love, share, and multiply.

D. Check-In and Accountability

1. **Reviewing Last Week's Commitments:** Accountability is vital for spiritual growth. Each participant should review the commitments they made during the previous week. Ask them to share how they did in three key areas:
 - Step 1. Obedience:** "How did you obey what God showed you last week?" Encourage participants to reflect on how they applied last week's passage or lesson. Were there areas where they succeeded? Were there struggles or obstacles they faced in obeying God's Word?
 - Step 2. Training Others:** "Who did you train in what you learned?" Multiplication is at the heart of the disciple-making process. Ask participants with whom they shared the lesson or principle.
 - Step 3. Sharing the Gospel:** "With whom did you share your story or God's story?"

Evangelism is a regular expectation. Ask if they shared their personal testimony or the Gospel with anyone in their relational circle. If they didn't have the opportunity, encourage them to make it a priority in the coming week.

2. **Encouraging Obedience:** If someone forgot or didn't have the opportunity to follow through on their commitments, encourage them to add them to the current week. If someone simply refuses to obey something they clearly heard from God then it should be treated as a church discipline issue.

III. LOOK UP (1/3 OF YOUR TIME)

- A. **Purpose:** This section focuses on engaging with God's Word. The goal is not just to gain knowledge but to discover truth together and apply it to life. The Word of God is central to our gatherings, and it must inform and shape how we live as disciples of Jesus.

B. **Pray for Understanding**

1. **Short Opening Prayer:** Start by asking God to speak through His Word. Prayer should be simple but sincere, example: "God, open our my hearts and minds to understand Your Word today."

C. **Read and Discuss**

1. **Reading the Passage:** Select a passage for the week and have the group read it aloud (See Appendix "3/3 GROUPS SERIES" for passages). Depending on the length, you may want to break it into sections and assign different participants to read.
2. **First Round of Questions:**
 - **What did you like about this passage?**
This question opens up the discussion by allowing people to express what stands out to them. It's non-threatening and encourages everyone to participate.
 - **What did you find challenging or hard to understand?**
This helps surface difficult aspects of the text and encourages deeper discussion.
3. **Reread the Passage:** After the initial discussion, read the passage again to ensure everyone is tracking. This repetition often leads to fresh insights or clarifications.

D. **Discovery Questions:**

1. **What can we learn about people from this passage?** – Encourage the group to reflect on human nature, struggles, and actions as revealed in the passage. Are there sins, behaviors, or attitudes that people in the passage exhibit, and what can we learn from them?
2. **What can we learn about God from this passage?** – Focus on what the text teaches about God’s character, will, or actions. Is God showing love, justice, patience, or something else? How does this affect how we relate to Him?

E. **Facilitator Role:** The facilitator should guide the discussion without teaching. Their role is to ask questions and help the group discover the truth of Scripture on their own. Encourage everyone to participate in answering the questions.

IV. **LOOK FORWARD (1/3 OF YOUR TIME)**

A. **Purpose:** The “Look Forward” segment ensures that the study of God’s Word leads to action. It encourages participants to apply what they’ve learned, train others, and share the Gospel. This is where discipleship becomes practical and real.

B. **Obey, Train, Share**

- **Time for Reflection:** Start this section with five minutes of silent prayer. During this time, have each person ask the Holy Spirit to show them how to apply what they’ve learned. This is where obedience becomes personal.

C. **Answer Three Key Questions:**

1. **How will I apply and obey this passage?**

- Each participant should write down a specific action they will take based on what they’ve learned. The commitment should be clear and measurable, such as “I will forgive my coworker this week” or “I will spend 10 minutes in prayer every morning.”

2. **Who will I train or share with about this passage?**

- Encourage each participant to identify someone they can share the lesson with or train in what they’ve learned. This could be a family member, friend, or coworker.

3. **Who does God want me to share my story or God's story with this week?**

- Ask participants to commit to sharing their testimony or the Gospel with someone in their relational network. Encourage boldness and reliance on the Holy Spirit.

V. PRACTICE

A. **Role-Playing and Practice:** Break into smaller groups of two or three and practice what participants have committed to do. For example, if someone committed to sharing the Gospel with a friend, have them role-play how that conversation might go. If someone committed to resist a specific temptation, have them practice what they will say or do in that moment.

- **Encourage Boldness:** This time of practice helps participants gain confidence in their commitments, ensuring they are more likely to follow through during the week.

VI. PRAY FOR ONE ANOTHER

A. **Praying in Small Groups:** Stay in your groups of two or three and pray specifically for the commitments each person made. Pray for strength, wisdom, and courage to obey what God has shown them. Ask God to prepare the hearts of those who will hear the Gospel or be trained during the week.

B. **Concluding Prayer:** After individual prayers, come together as a group and close the meeting with a final prayer, asking for God's continued guidance and presence.

VII. ENDING THE MEETING

A. **Share the Lord's Supper:** Share communion as a group, remembering the sacrifice of Christ and His call to follow Him.

B. **Eat a Meal Together:** Many groups conclude their meetings with a shared meal. Eating together builds deeper relationships and allows for continued fellowship. This practice mirrors the early church's gatherings, where they "broke bread in their homes and ate together with glad and sincere hearts" (Acts 2:46).

VIII. PRACTICAL EXERCISES FOR LEADING A 3/3 GROUP

- A. **Facilitator Practice:** Rotate group members into the role of facilitator, allowing each person to lead part of the meeting. This helps develop new leaders and ensures that the group remains reproducible.
- B. **Debrief Sessions:** After each meeting, take 10-15 minutes to debrief. Discuss what went well and what could be improved. This feedback process helps refine the group's effectiveness and encourages personal growth.

NOTE – There is a suggested series of passages 3/3 Groups can study in the Appendix.

This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).

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